

Chapter | 11 | Reports for Information and Analysis



>>> Chapter Objectives

In this chapter students will

- Learn how informative reports are used to share information and keep records in organizations
- Learn the ABC format for four types of informative reports: activity reports, progress reports, regulatory reports, and lab reports
- Learn how analytical reports are used to guide decision making in organizations
- Learn the ABC format for four types of analytical reports: problem analysis, recommendation reports, feasibility studies, and equipment evaluations
- Read and analyze model informative and analytical reports

Alan Murphy, a salesperson for M-Global's St. Paul office, has a full day ahead. Besides having to make some sales calls in the morning, he must complete two short reports back in the office. The first is a short progress report to Brasstown Bearings, a company that recently hired M-Global to train its technical staff in effective sales techniques. As manager of the project, Alan has overseen the efforts of three M-Global trainers for the last three weeks. According to the contract, he must send a progress report to Brasstown every three weeks during the project. Alan's second report is internal. His boss wants a short report recommending ways that M-Global can pursue more training projects like the Brasstown job.

Like Alan Murphy, you will write many different kinds of reports in your career. The two basic document formats that were presented in Chapter 10 are a starting place for writing reports. This chapter and Chapter 12 explain how to write documents to meet specific purposes. The common types of reports discussed in this chapter can be formatted as informal or formal documents, but they are adapted to specific needs and contexts. This chapter discusses reports that convey information or analyze problems. Chapter 12 discusses proposals and white papers, documents whose purpose is primarily persuasive.

The strategies for developing and organizing reports in this chapter will help you create documents that meet your readers' need for information, your own need to create effective documents that project a professional image, and the need to adapt documents to your organizational context. The context in which you are writing is a critical concern for these informative and analytical reports. Not only does it help you identify your audience, but it also can affect the content and structure of your

reports. The guidelines in this chapter are just that—guidelines. Reports like these emerge naturally from organizational contexts, so you should adapt the ABC formats in this chapter to the specific characteristics of the situations and problems that are being reported. You should also adapt your reports to the expectations of your organization and of your clients' organizations.

Report types vary from company to company. The ones described here are only a sampling of what you will be asked to write on the job. Because the reports discussed here may have different labels in different books and organizations, we include definitions to explain how we group and identify each type of report that we discuss.

The sections that follow include an ABC format for each report being discussed and some brief case studies from M-Global. Well-organized reports incorporate the writing patterns described in Chapter 4 and often include the elements of technical communication discussed in Chapters 7 and 8. Remember to consult Chapter 4 if you need to review general patterns of organization used in short and long reports, such as cause-effect; consult Chapters 7 and 8 if you need to review common genres of technical communication, such as technical descriptions. If you master these eight informative and analytical reports, you can probably handle other types that come your way.

At the end of the chapter are examples with marginal annotations. They give you specific, real-life applications of the chapter's writing guidelines. These models will help you complete chapter assignments and do actual reports on the job. During your career, you will write many types of informal reports other than those presented here. If you grasp this chapter's principles, however, you can adapt to other formats.

>>> Four Common Informative Reports

Informative reports are one of the most common types of documents used in organizations. They generally serve two purposes. First, they provide a record of what individuals, departments, and the organization have accomplished and of how they have proceeded. These re-

ports may be archived for future reference, either by employees or by researchers. Second, they are used to share information, either with supervisors or between departments. Because these reports are so common, organizations often create templates, or even forms, for them. As a result, the abstracts and conclusions in informative reports are often quite short.

Activity Reports

Most organizations require activity reports to provide a record of ongoing tasks, specific activities, and special projects, as well as the accomplishments of individuals and departments. These informative reports may simply be read by supervisors and managers who need to know what is happening in their divisions, or they may become part of a file for future reference. This book uses the following definition for activity reports:

Activity report: An informal report, usually directed within your own organization, which summarizes an event or records work on a specific project or during a specific time period.

Many activity reports are written at set periods, such as weekly, monthly, or quarterly. These *periodic reports* may be used simply to inform others of what is happening in a department or on a project, or they may become part of an employment record. In some organizations, managers publish their department's periodic reports as internal blogs so that everyone in the organization can find out what other departments are doing. This practice makes it easier for departments to collaborate.

In some organizations, employees are required to submit periodic self-evaluations in which they list their activities and accomplishments. These become part of their personnel record and may be the basis for promotion. Weekly activity reports may also be submitted as time sheets so that time devoted to specific projects can be recorded or individual clients can be billed.

Some activity reports include information about specific events, rather than about activities over a period of time. For example, an organization may require a *trip report* from employees who travel to meet clients, work in other branches, or participate in professional training workshops. Another type of activity report is the *incident report*, which provides initial information about accidents in a factory or at a work site.

Often, these types of activity reports are submitted as forms. One easy way to create these forms is to use the table tools in your word processor. Start with a basic table, and then join columns or rows to provide adequate blanks for information, like the example in Figure 11–1. You can also hide cell borders, or leave borders to serve as underlines to indicate where information is to be completed, as in the example in Figure 11–2. If the form is made available through an organization's intranet, the use of table tools makes completing an electronic version of the form easy; it prevents formatting problems that occur with forms that are created only with text and underscores or graphic lines.

ABC Format for Activity Reports

Because activity reports are routine workplace documents, they often do not need much context to help readers understand why they are receiving the report. Some activity reports, such as time sheets, trip reports, and incident reports, may even be submitted

Trip Report

This report form must be completed and signed by the employee and supervisor for all travel related to M-Global business. One copy of the form should be submitted with monthly departmental reports. If the employee is seeking reimbursement for travel expenses, one copy of the form with original receipts attached must be filed with the M-Global branch Accounting Office.

Employee name:				Employee number:			
Department:							
Destination:				Dates:			
Purpose of travel:							
Findings/Results:							
Transportation expenses:							
	Personal car						
	Airfare						
	Other						
Lodging:							
Meals:							
Other:							
Employee signature			Date	Supervisor signature			Date
				Supervisor name (please print)			



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■ Figure 11-1 ■ Form created with basic table tools

Trip Report

This report form must be completed and signed by the employee and supervisor for all travel related to M-Global business. One copy of the form is to be submitted with monthly departmental reports. If the employee is seeking reimbursement for travel expenses, one copy of the form with original receipts attached must be filed with the M-Global branch Accounting Office.

Employee name: _____ Employee number: _____

Department: _____

Destination: _____ Dates: _____

Purpose of travel: _____

Findings/Results: _____

Transportation expenses:

Personal car: _____

Airfare: _____

Other: _____

Lodging: _____

Meals: _____

Other: _____

Employee signature

Date

Supervisor signature

Date

Supervisor name (please print)



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■ **Figure 11-2** ■ Form created as table with some borders removed

as forms. However, activity reports should still include an abstract, because the number of them generated each month makes it necessary to provide information to someone accessing them at a later date.

Since activity reports usually describe events, you may think that they should use a chronological pattern of organization; however, this is probably the least effective way to report your activities. Instead, the body of an activity report should group the activities into useful classifications, for example, by type of activity or by project. The conclusion of your activity report should indicate which activities will continue in the future, especially if the activities are related to specific projects. It should also indicate how problems reported in the body will be addressed.

ABC Format: Activity Reports

- **ABSTRACT:** Time period, project, or event covered in report.
- **BODY:** List of activities or events
 - Organization that emphasizes type of activity, by project, or by client
 - Problems important to reader
- **CONCLUSION:** Future actions
 - Actions for continuing and ongoing activities
 - Plans for addressing problems or for the time period covered by the next report

M-Global Case Study for an Activity Report

Model 11–1 on pages 374–75 shows the rather routine nature of most activity reports. In this case, Nancy Fairbanks is simply submitting her usual monthly report. The greatest challenge in such reports is to classify, divide, and label information in such a way that readers can find what they need quickly. Fairbanks selected the kind of substantive headings that help the reader locate information (e.g., “Jones Fill Project,” “Performance Reviews”).

Progress Reports

Some short reports are intended to cover progress on a specific project. They can be directed inside or outside your organization and are defined as follows:

Progress report: An informal report that provides your manager or client with details about work on a specific project. Often you agree at the beginning of a project to submit a certain number of progress reports at certain intervals. The final progress report, submitted when a project is completed, is often called a *project completion report*.

Progress reports contain mostly objective data. Yet they are sometimes written in a persuasive manner. Progress reports tell your supervisor or the client that your project is on task, on time, and on budget. If you have encountered problems with any of these elements, the progress report should offer an explanation of what has happened and how the problem will be addressed. After all, you are trying to put forth the best case for the work you have completed. The next section provides an ABC format for these two report types.

ABC Format for Progress Reports

Whether internal or external, progress reports follow a basic ABC format. Whether the project report is being written as a letter or memo, the project itself should be clearly identified in a subject line by project title or by a reference number. This information should also appear in the abstract, with background information about the history and scope of the project. Because progress reports describe work over a period of time, it may seem as if

ABC Format: Progress Report

- **ABSTRACT:** Project and general progress (e.g., second week of a four-week project)
 - Capsule summary of main project(s)
 - Main progress to date or since last report
- **BODY:** Description of work completed since last report
 - Organization emphasizes task, chronology, or both
 - Clear reference to any dead ends that may have taken considerable time but yielded no results
 - Explanation of delays or incomplete work
 - Description of work remaining on project(s), organized by task, by time, or by both
 - Reference to attachments that may contain more specific information
- **CONCLUSION:** Brief restatement of work since last reporting period
 - Expression of confidence or concern about overall work on project(s)
 - Indication of your willingness to make any adjustments the reader may want to suggest

the body of progress reports should be organized chronologically; however, like activity reports, progress reports should be organized by type of activity. They usually include a section that describes problems or delays in the project and a clear timeline for completion of the remaining work on the project. The conclusion should summarize the progress since the previous progress report (or since the beginning of the project, if you are writing the first project report), and it should predict what will be accomplished before the next report is submitted.

M-Global Case Study for a Progress Report

As Model 11–2 on pages 376–377 indicates, Scott Sampson, M-Global’s personnel manager, is in the midst of an internal project being conducted for Jeannie McDuff, Vice President of Domestic Operations. Sampson’s goal is to find ways to improve the company’s training for technical employees. Having completed two of three phases, he is reporting his progress to McDuff. Note that Sampson organizes the body sections by task. This arrangement helps focus the reader’s attention on the two main accomplishments—the successful phone interviews and the potentially useful survey.

Also note that Sampson adopts a persuasive tone at the end of the report—that is, he uses his solid progress as a way to emphasize the importance of the project. In this sense, he is “selling” the project to his “internal customer,” Jeannie McDuff, who ultimately is in the position to make decisions about the future of technical training at M-Global.

Regulatory Reports

Most organizations are required to submit reports that show they are in compliance with federal, state, or local regulations, or with standards set by professional organizations. In some highly regulated industries such as banking, energy, and insurance, technical communicators may be hired primarily to maintain, update, and submit these *regulatory reports*. However, in most cases, technical communicators are responsible primarily for designing and editing these reports.

Regulatory reports include quarterly and annual financial reports, as well as audit and compliance reports for a wide range of regulations—from workplace safety to compliance with employment regulations to environmental impact. The following is a working definition of regulatory reports:

Regulatory report: A report written for an external audience—a regulatory agency—asserting and documenting an organization’s compliance with standards and regulations. Regulatory reports may be submitted at required intervals and may use a required format.

Regulatory reports may be formatted as informal or as formal documents, and they are usually written both internal audiences (such as a board of directors) and external audiences (such as regulatory agencies or stockholders).

ABC Format for Regulatory Reports

The organization of regulatory reports can vary widely, depending on the requirements of the regulatory agency and the type of information that is being communicated. However, the basic ABC format is useful for regulatory reports.

A special type of regulatory report is the *annual report* issued by publicly held companies, companies that sell stock. In the United States, these reports are required by the Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC), and they are meant to inform stockholders and potential stockholders about the company's financial health. The only information that is required by SEC regulations is financial data; however, many companies use their annual report as a way to promote the company to current and potential stockholders. Annual reports are often bound in attractive covers, with photographs of employees or company locations. They usually include a letter from the president of the company, and they often promote a company's philanthropic activities. Accountants create the annual report material required by federal regulations, but marketing or public relations departments often design and create additional material for annual reports. Managers of individual branches or divisions may be asked to contribute stories for the annual report, and publications departments may be responsible for combining all of these materials into an attractive, positive document.



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ABC Format: Regulatory Reports

- **ABSTRACT:** Reference to standards or regulations that are the subject of the report.
 - Summary of the findings, including statement of extent to which the organization is in compliance
 - Summary of recommended actions
- **BODY:** Detailed information about the findings
 - Organization that emphasizes required activities or documents
 - Description of observations
 - Description of problems observed
 - Data that support observations
- **CONCLUSION:** Summary of degree of compliance with regulations
 - Recommendations for improvement of compliance
 - Summary of consequences if problems are not addressed in a timely manner

M-Global Case Study for a Regulatory Report

Asbestos removal is a growing part of M-Global's business, and regulations for asbestos removal vary from state to state. As a hazardous materials specialist in the St. Paul office, Ken Liu is responsible for informing state agencies whenever his office is removing asbestos from a work site. He meets this requirement by filing the report in Model 11–3 on pages 378–381. Like many regulatory reports, this report follows a template, in this case one provided by the Minnesota Department of Transportation. The form identifies the specific regulations and asks for all professional certifications. Because there are documents required for each step of the process, the template specifies how those documents are to be submitted in the report.



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Lab Reports

College students write lab reports for courses in science, engineering, psychology, and other subjects. This type of report also exists in technical organizations such as hospitals, engineering firms, and computer companies. Lab reports record and communicate the results of laboratory studies; therefore, they are primarily informative. However, lab results may be included in the findings in analytical reports. For example, a lab report that records the results of soil core analysis may provide data for a report that recommends which of three building sites is most suitable for construction of a school. The lab report varies in format from organization to organization (and

from instructor to instructor, in the case of college courses). This section presents a format to use when no other instructions have been given. A working definition follows:

Lab report: An informal report that describes work done in any laboratory. It may be directed to someone inside or outside your own organization. Also, it may stand on its own, or it may become part of a larger report that uses the laboratory work as supporting detail.

The next section shows a typical ABC format for lab reports, with the types of information that might appear in the three main sections.

ABC Format: Lab Report

- **ABSTRACT:** Summary of laboratory investigation
 - Purpose of laboratory investigation
 - Nature of investigation, such as material tested, process analyzed
 - Qualifications of investigator
 - Equipment used
 - Capsule summary of results
- **BODY:** Purpose or hypothesis of lab work
 - Organization that emphasizes procedures or methods used in the lab test
 - Unusual problems or occurrences
 - Results of the test with reference to your expectations (results may appear in conclusion, instead)
- **CONCLUSION:** Statement or restatement of main results
 - Recommendations, if requested
 - Implications of lab test for further work

ABC Format for Lab Reports

The audience for lab reports may be very technical, as when a team of organic chemists reports their findings for other organic chemists, or it may be much less technical, as when a real estate agent has asked to have a property tested for radon. You should adapt your language, graphics, and technical detail to meet the needs of your reader. Lab reports are often written in the passive voice because the reader is more interested in the processes being reported than in who conducted the investigation. Whether simple or complicated, lab reports usually can be organized using the ABC format. The abstract includes appropriate background information that summarizes the investigation and demonstrates the quality of the results. The body of lab reports is usually organized by topics, such as purpose of the work, procedures, problems, results, and implications. If recommendations have been requested, these should be included in the conclusion.

M-Global Case Study for a Lab Report

Model 11–4 on pages 382–383 shows an M-Global lab report that is not part of a larger document. In this case, the client sent M-Global some soils taken from borings made into the earth. M-Global analyzed the samples in its company laboratory and

drew some conclusions about the kind of rock from which the samples were taken. The report writer, a geologist named Joseph Rappaport, uses the body of the report to provide background information, lab materials, procedures, and problems encountered. Note that the report body uses process explanation, an element of technical communication covered in Chapter 8.

>>> Four Common Analytical Reports

Analytical reports help readers understand and solve problems by explaining the results of an investigation and the consequences of possible courses of action. Because the investigation is situated in a specific workplace context, the content and organization of analytical reports should be closely tied to the specific workplace situation being addressed. Although analytical reports may recommend a course of action, they emphasize the data and reasoning that led to the recommendations. Analytical reports generally do not propose specific steps for implementing actions; those are usually presented in proposals, which are discussed in Chapter 12.

When beginning the process of writing an analytical report, you should answer these questions:

1. What is the situation or problem that has prompted the report?
2. Will the reader use the report to understand a situation, to solve a problem, or to implement improvements?
3. What information does the reader need to act?
4. What criteria will be used to make a decision?
5. What information do the criteria call for?

Identifying criteria for decision making is an important step in the analytical report process, but it is one that is often overlooked. Carolyn Rude¹ explains three common categories of criteria: technical, managerial, and social:

- **Technical criteria** help identify whether something is possible: Does the organization have the expertise, capacity, or physical space for the change? Does the change meet long-term needs for flexibility and upgrades?
- **Managerial criteria** help identify whether something is effective: How will the change affect the company financially? What personnel costs are there in hiring and training?
- **Social criteria** help identify whether something is desirable: How will the change affect employees? Is the change safe for employees, customers, and the environment? Is the change consistent with the organization's culture and ethics?

After you have established the criteria for evaluating the particular situation that the report will analyze, you should gather data using the research techniques that were discussed in

¹Some of the information in this section is based on the excellent discussion in C. Rude. (1995). The report for decision making: Genre and inquiry. *Journal of Business and Technical Communication*, 9(2), 170–205.

Chapter 9. Choose sources that will help you find information appropriate to the subject of your report.

Problem Analyses

Every organization faces both routine and complex problems. Routine problems are often handled without much paperwork; they are discussed and then solved. However, other problems must often be described in reports, particularly if they involve many people, are difficult to solve, or have been brewing for a long time. Use the following working definition of a *report* that analyzes a problem:

Problem analysis: A report that presents readers with a detailed description of problems in areas such as personnel, equipment, products, and services. Its main goal is to provide objective information so that the readers can choose the next step. Any opinions must be well supported by facts.

It may be helpful to approach a problem analysis as a research project, like the ones discussed in Chapter 9. Note that solutions to problems are not mentioned; this chapter deals separately with (1) problem analyses, whose main focus is problems; and (2) recommendation reports, whose main focus is solutions. Of course, be aware that during your career, you may be called on to write reports that combine both types.

ABC Format for Problem Analyses

Like other analytical reports, *problem analyses* fit the simple ABC (Abstract/Body/Conclusion) format recommended throughout this text. The three sections contain some or all of the following information, depending on the specific report. The abstract should provide the readers with all background information about the problem that prompted the report. The body of the report should clearly identify sources of information and methods used in the analysis, and it should use the pattern of organization that is most appropriate for the problem being discussed. The conclusion may include a general statement of the next steps to be taken, but it should emphasize the findings and the importance of the problem.

ABC Format: Problem Analysis

- **ABSTRACT:** Purpose of report
 - Capsule summary of problems covered in report discussion
- **BODY:** Background on source of problems
 - Well-organized description of the problems observed
 - Data that support your observations
 - Consequences of the problems
- **CONCLUSION:** Brief restatement of main problems (unless report is so short that such restatement would seem repetitious)
 - Degree of urgency required in handling problems
 - Suggested next step

M-Global Case Study for a Problem Analysis

Model 11–5 on pages 384–385 presents a sample problem analysis that follows this chapter’s guidelines. Harold Marshal, a longtime M-Global employee, supervises all technical work aboard the *Seeker II*, a boat that M-Global leases during the summer. Staffed with several technicians and engineers, the boat is used to collect and test soil samples from the ocean floor. Different clients purchase these data, such as oil companies that must place oil rigs safely and telecommunications companies that must lay cable.

After a summer on the *Seeker II*, Harold has severe reservations about the safety and technical adequacy of the boat. Yet he knows that his supervisor, Jan Stillwright, will require detailed support of any complaints before she seriously considers negotiating a new boat contract next season. Given this critical audience, Harold focuses on specific problems that affect (1) the safety of the crew, (2) the accuracy of the technical work performed, and (3) the morale of the crew. He believes that this pragmatic approach, rather than an emotional appeal, will best persuade his boss that the problem is serious.

Most problem analyses contain both facts and opinions. As the writer, you must make special efforts to separate the two, for the following reason: Most readers want the opportunity to draw their own conclusions about the problem. Also, you must support all opinions with facts.

Recommendation Reports

Like problem analysis reports, recommendation reports include facts and opinions, because they include the writer's interpretation of data. Use the following working definition for recommendation reports:

Recommendation report: A report that presents readers with specific suggestions that affect areas such as personnel, equipment, procedures, products, and services. Although the report's main purpose is to persuade, every recommendation must be supported by objective data.

Recommendation reports can be either internal or external documents, both of which follow the ABC format.

ABC Format for Recommendation Reports

Problem analyses and recommendation reports sometimes overlap in content. You may recommend solutions in a problem analysis, just as you may analyze problems in a recommendation report. The ABC format assumes that you want to mention the problem briefly in the abstract before proceeding to discuss solutions. The body of your recommendation report should include the options that have been considered, as well as data to support considering or rejecting each option. You may decide that more than one option is acceptable, but that one is preferable. The reasons for your recommendation should be explained in the conclusion.

M-Global Case Study for a Recommendation Report

Model 11–6 (pp. 386–387) shows a typical recommendation report written at M-Global. The servers at M-Global are several years old and are no longer adequate. The writer, Mike Tran, is a member of the Information Services Department, and has been asked by



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ABC Format: Recommendation Report

- **ABSTRACT:** Purpose of report
 - Brief reference to problem to which recommendations respond
 - Capsule summary of recommendations covered in report discussion
- **BODY:** Details about problem, if necessary
 - Description of options
 - Data that support recommendations (with reference to attachments, if any)
 - Main benefits of recommendations
 - Any possible drawbacks
- **CONCLUSION:** Brief statement or restatement of main recommendations (optional)
 - The main benefit of recommended change
 - Your offer to help with next step

his supervisor, Greg Bass, to recommend a course of action to solve the problem. The report clearly identifies the context for which it was written, lists criteria for making a decision, and recommends a solution to the problem.

Feasibility Studies

Much like recommendation reports, feasibility studies guide readers toward a particular action. Another similarity is that both report types can be either in-house or external. However, feasibility studies are usually solicited by the reader who needs to make a decision. Therefore, they do not advocate strongly for a single solution. Instead, they compare alternatives in such a way that a reader can make an informed decision about a course of action. This book uses the following working definition of feasibility studies:

Feasibility study: A document written to show the *practicality* of a proposed policy, product, service, or other change within an organization. Often prompted by ideas suggested in a *proposal*, a feasibility study examines details such as costs, alternatives, and likely effects. Although they must reflect the objectivity of a report, most feasibility studies also try to convince readers either (1) to adopt or reject the one idea discussed or (2) to adopt one of several alternatives presented in the study.

ABC Format: Feasibility Study

- **ABSTRACT:** Capsule summary of information for the most important readers (i.e., the decision makers)
 - Brief statement about who has authorized the study and for what purpose
 - Brief mention of the criteria used during the evaluation
 - Brief reference to your recommendation
- **BODY:** Details that support whatever conclusions and recommendations the study contains, working logically from fact toward opinion
 - Organization that compares advantages and disadvantages of each option
 - Description of evaluation criteria used during your study
 - Description of exactly *what* was evaluated and *how*, especially if you are comparing several items
- **CONCLUSION:** Wrap-up in which you state conclusions and recommendations resulting from the study

Feasibility studies are often part of a larger process. They may be preceded by a problem analysis and a recommendation report or proposal. Once a problem has been identified and analyzed and a response has been suggested, a feasibility study may be conducted to determine if the proposed action is appropriate for the particular situation in the organization. If the proposed action is feasible and desirable, the feasibility study may be followed by a plan of action, including the development of guidelines and training materials.

ABC Format for Feasibility Studies

Like other forms of technical writing, good feasibility studies have the basic three-part structure of abstract, body, and conclusion—although the exact headings you choose may vary from report to report. The abstract of your feasibility study should clearly identify the purpose of the study and should briefly summarize your findings and

recommendations. The body should identify the subject of your study, and it should clearly explain the criteria that were used in your evaluation. Feasibility studies use a comparison pattern of organization, presenting the advantages and disadvantages of each alternative. The conclusion section should make your findings and recommendations clear to the reader, while inviting questions and discussion.

M-Global Case Study for a Feasibility Study

Like many feasibility studies, Model 11–7 on pages 388–395 was written as part of a larger process. The writers, members of M-Global’s Information Systems department, had previously submitted an informal proposal, recommending that M-Global begin using open-source software. The proposal cited specific cost savings, but Greg Bass, Director of Information Systems, wanted more information before moving forward. Although this feasibility study does include recommendations, it presents information in a way that allows Greg to make the final decision. It also suggests more actions be taken (the establishment of guidelines) before fully implementing the proposal.

Equipment Evaluations

Every organization uses some kind of equipment, and someone has to help buy, maintain, or replace it. Because companies put so much money into this part of their business, evaluating equipment has become an important activity. Following is a working definition of evaluation reports:

Equipment evaluation: An informal report that provides objective data about how equipment has, or has not, functioned. The report may cover topics such as machinery, tools, vehicles, office supplies, computer hardware, and computer software.

Like a problem analysis, an equipment evaluation may focus only on problems; or like a recommendation report, it may go on to suggest a change in equipment. Whatever its focus, an equipment evaluation must provide a well-documented review of the exact manner in which equipment performed.

ABC Format for Equipment Evaluations

Equipment evaluations that are informal reports should include some or all of the points listed here. The abstract of equipment evaluations should inform readers of the reasons for the evaluation and the scope of the report. The body of equipment evaluations may be organized part-by-part, or they may emphasize



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ABC Format: Equipment Evaluation

- **ABSTRACT:** Purpose of report
 - Capsule summary of what your report says about the equipment
 - Reason for the evaluation
- **BODY:** Thorough description of the equipment being evaluated
 - Well-organized critique, either analyzing the parts of one piece of equipment or contrasting several pieces of similar equipment according to selected criteria
 - Additional supporting data, with reference to any attachments
- **CONCLUSION:** Brief restatement of major findings, conclusions, or recommendations

process—either how the equipment is used or how it functions—or they may compare the new equipment to existing equipment. Remember that in this type of report, the discussion must include evaluation criteria most important to the *readers*, not you. The conclusion should provide readers with the information that they need to make decisions about the use of the equipment.

M-Global Case Study for an Equipment Evaluation

Like other firms, M-Global relies on word processing for almost all internal and external documents. Model 11–8 (pp. 396–397) contains an evaluation of a new word-processing package used on a trial basis. Melanie Frank, office manager in San Francisco, conducted the trial in her office and wrote the report to the branch manager, Hank Worley. Note that she analyzes each of the software’s five main features and then ends with a recommendation, much as in a recommendation report.

Pay special attention to the tone and argumentative structure of this example. Frank shows restraint in her enthusiasm, knowing that facts will be more convincing than opinions. Indeed, every claim about Best Choice software is supported either by evidence from her trial or by a logical explanation. For example, her praise of the file management feature is supported by the experience of a field engineer who used the system for three days, and her statement about the well-written user’s guide is supported by the few calls made to the Best Choice support center during the trial.

>>> Chapter Summary

- Organizations use informative reports to keep records and to share information between departments.
- Informative reports are influenced by the workplace context for which they are written.
- Activity reports include information about ongoing tasks, specific activities, or special projects.
- Progress reports provide information about specific projects.
- Regulatory reports provide information about an organization’s compliance with federal, state, or local regulations or with professional standards.
- Lab reports provide information about the results of work done in laboratories.
- Organizations use analytical reports to understand problems and make informed decisions.
- Analytical reports should include clear criteria for analysis and recommendations.
- Problem analysis reports provide objective data to describe and understand a problem.
- Recommendation reports use objective data to support specific suggestions about how to solve a problem or improve the operations in an organization.
- Feasibility studies analyze the practicality of a proposed policy, product, service, or other change.
- Equipment evaluations describe how well equipment has functioned.